

Reach Without Revenue: Why Fan Controlled Football Failed

A data-driven case study of engagement, capital dependence and roster continuity in a digital-first football league, 2021-2023

Abstract. Fan Controlled Football (FCF) let viewers call plays in real time, reported nearly 10 million live views in its first season, raised a \$40 million Series A in January 2022, doubled from four to eight teams, and then cancelled its planned third season in 2023 after a cash crunch. This paper asks why a league with visible audience traction failed within roughly 17 months of its largest raise. Using a compiled public-record dataset of 12 team-seasons, league audience and funding disclosures, and benchmarks from five other spring or alternative leagues, we find that the evidence does not support a demand-failure story. It supports a conversion-and-capital story: reported reach was never matched by any disclosed revenue stream, the league scaled its footprint on external capital drawn heavily from a crypto and Web3 investor base, and only 40% of 2021 players returned for 2022. We score seven candidate explanations on a transparent rubric and rank capital dependence first. The central limitation is that no audited FCF financials are public, so the thesis is a best-supported inference, not a proven single cause.

1. Introduction

The standard explanation for an alternative football league's collapse is that nobody watched. FCF is a poor fit for that explanation. The league reported 735,000 live views in week one of its 2021 season, 2.1 million at the playoffs, and, in 2022, 2.4 million live views per week across Twitch, NBCLX, DAZN and other outlets, plus 250,000 app downloads. Investors responded: Animoca Brands and Delphi Digital led a \$40 million Series A in January 2022.

Yet by June 2023 the league's operator said a cash crunch had ended the planned season and announced a pivot toward technology licensing and franchise sales. This paper treats that contrast as the research problem: *what separated FCF's attention from a self-sustaining business?*

We make three contributions. First, we build a cleaned dataset and publish a corrections log, including an error in how the 2021 champion was recorded. Second, we separate audience metrics into incompatible measurement families rather than ranking them on one axis. Third, we score competing explanations on an explicit rubric so that readers can disagree with the weights instead of with an assertion.

2. Background: the base rate for spring and alternative football

Failure itself is not unusual in this market. Table 1 lists comparable ventures. FCF's two-season lifespan is typical of the category, which means the interesting question is mechanism, not whether it happened.

League	Played	Outcome
USFL (1983)	3 seasons	Folded after antitrust verdict and failed fall-schedule move
XFL (2001)	1 season	Ended after one year despite strong debut ratings
AAF (2019)	8 weeks	Collapsed mid-season amid funding failure
XFL (2020)	5 weeks	Suspended by COVID-19; filed for bankruptcy
USFL (2022) / XFL (2023)	2 and 1 seasons	Merged into the UFL for 2024

League	Played	Outcome
FCF (2021-22)	2 seasons	Season 3 cancelled in 2023; pivot to licensing

Table 1. Lifespans of selected alternative football leagues (author compilation from public record; not part of the dataset workbook).

3. Data and methods

The dataset contains 12 team-seasons (4 in 2021, 8 in 2022), 21 player-leader records, five audience observations, financial and distribution records, a 13-event timeline, and eight comparator-league rows. FCF figures come from league announcements and press coverage of those announcements; comparator figures come from trade and league reporting.

Measurement discipline

FCF reports *platform live views*. The USFL, XFL and UFL report *average viewers per game* from panel-based measurement. These are different quantities, so Figure 1 draws them on separate axes and this paper never ranks one against the other. A view is not a unique viewer, and a download is not an active user.

Corrections to earlier drafts

Reviewing the original dataset and brief against source records surfaced the following, all fixed in the accompanying workbook: (1) the 2021 team sheet recorded Glacier Boyz as champion; the Wild Aces won the People's Championship 46-40 over Glacier Boyz; (2) the earlier brief's funnel cited '20M+ reported live views in 2022', which no source in the dataset supports, so it was removed; (3) the comparator sheet had shifted columns for several leagues; (4) the Series-A-to-cancellation interval was recorded as -18 months where about 17 is correct; (5) stray citation markers were removed; (6) USFL 2022 appears as 695K in the chart data but the cited source states 715K, so the figure should be re-verified before publication; (7) the 2.5M opening-week figure for 2022 appears in the analysis but not in the audience sheet and is treated here as reported but not independently verified.

Statistical approach

With 12 team-seasons and no game-level audience or revenue data, inference is limited. We use descriptive statistics and two rank-based association tests, report exact values, and avoid regression. We do not infer revenue from funding.

Figure 1. Two measurement families: deliberately drawn on separate axes

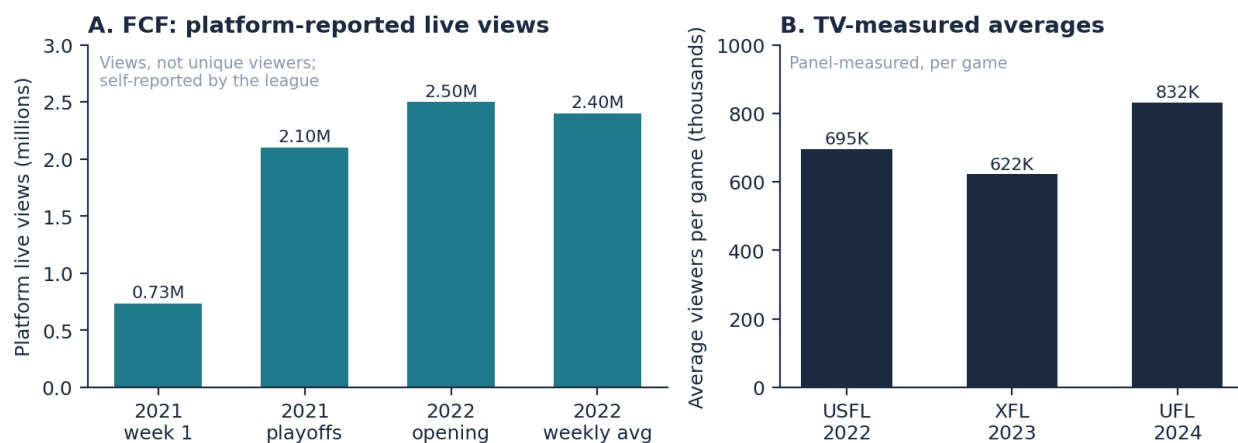


Figure 1 compares only like with like. Left: FCF self-reported live views. Right: TV-measured averages for comparator leagues. The two panels share no axis by design.

4. Results

4.1 Audience: strong, growing, and unmonetized in the public record

FCF's reported reach rose from 735,000 in week one of 2021 to 2.1 million at the playoffs (+186%), and its reported 2022 opening week of 2.5 million is 240% above the 2021 opener. A league with weak demand does not report this trajectory. The relevant gap is further down the funnel. Figure 2 shows what the public record contains: two top-of-funnel counts and no disclosed subscriber, ticket, sponsorship or revenue figure.

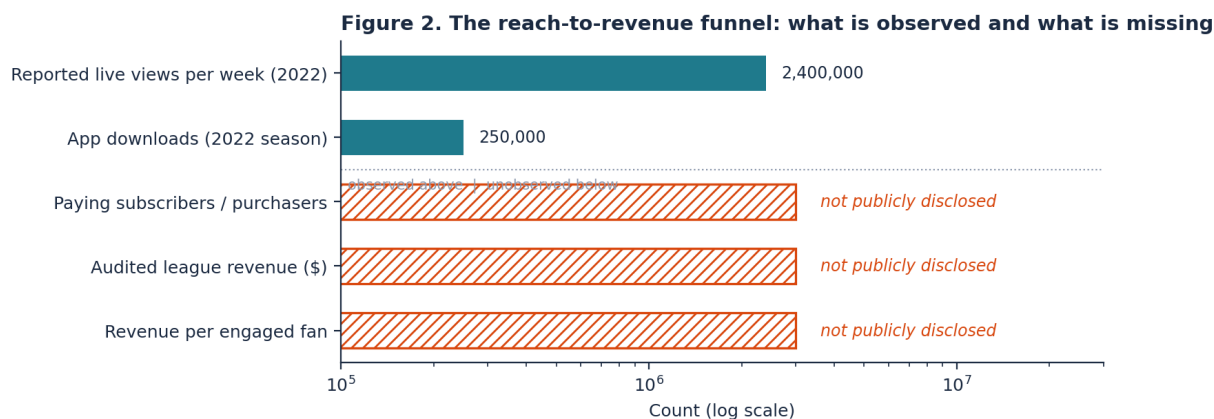


Figure 2. Observed funnel layers (solid) and layers absent from the public record (hatched, orange).

4.2 Competitive product

The football itself was not obviously broken. Across the 12 team-seasons, win percentage and point differential are moderately associated (Pearson $r = 0.52$, $p = 0.085$; Spearman $\rho = 0.59$, $p = 0.044$; $n = 12$, pooled across seasons, so treat as exploratory). Scoring per team-game fell from 33.8 points in 2021 to 27.3 in 2022 (-19%), and the mean absolute point differential per game roughly doubled from 2.0 to 4.0 as the league widened from four to eight teams.

The most striking pattern is the outcome of the 2022 playoffs. The champion Zappers finished 3-4, ranked **8 of 8** in regular-season point differential (-38), and, according to league coverage, began the season 0-4.

Championship results were largely decoupled from regular-season strength. That is consistent with an entertainment product and does not itself indicate a problem, but it limits how much the standings can tell fans about team quality.

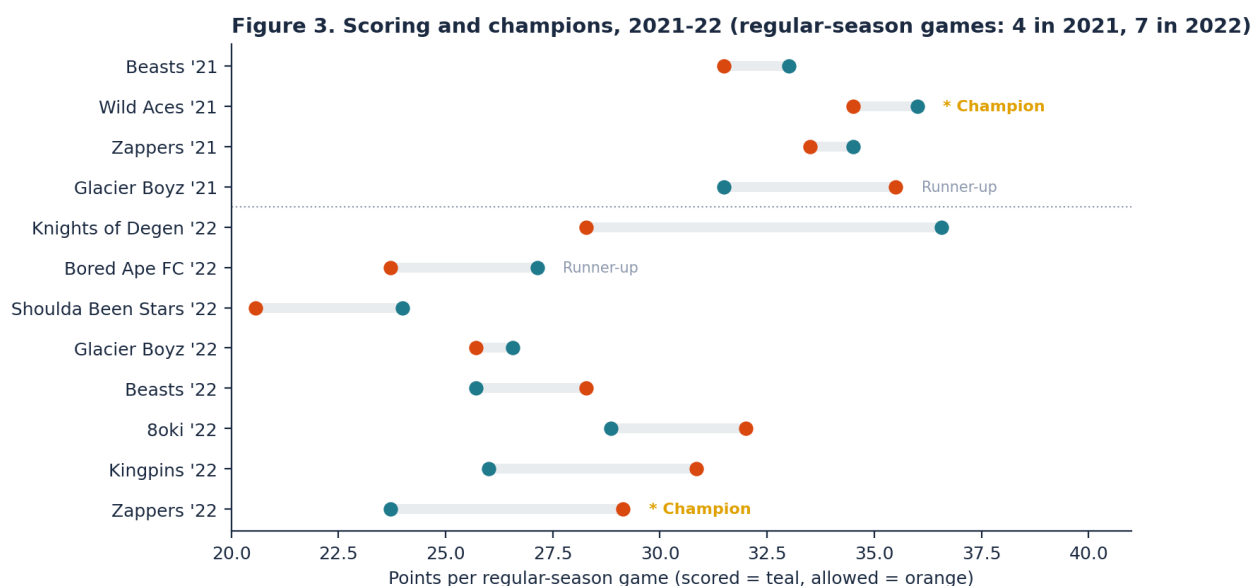


Figure 3. Per-game scoring for each team-season, ordered within season by point differential. Stars mark champions; the 2021 champion Wild Aces is shown correctly.

4.3 Players: a continuity problem

The league reported that only 40% of 2021 players returned in 2022, despite a \$100-per-week raise for those who did. The underlying roster count is not published, so no confidence interval can be computed, and a high-turnover player pool is common in developmental leagues. The significance is structural: the product was built on recognizable personalities and fan-assigned play-calling, and it entered its largest expansion while rebuilding most of its roster.

Figure 4. Of every 100 players in 2021...



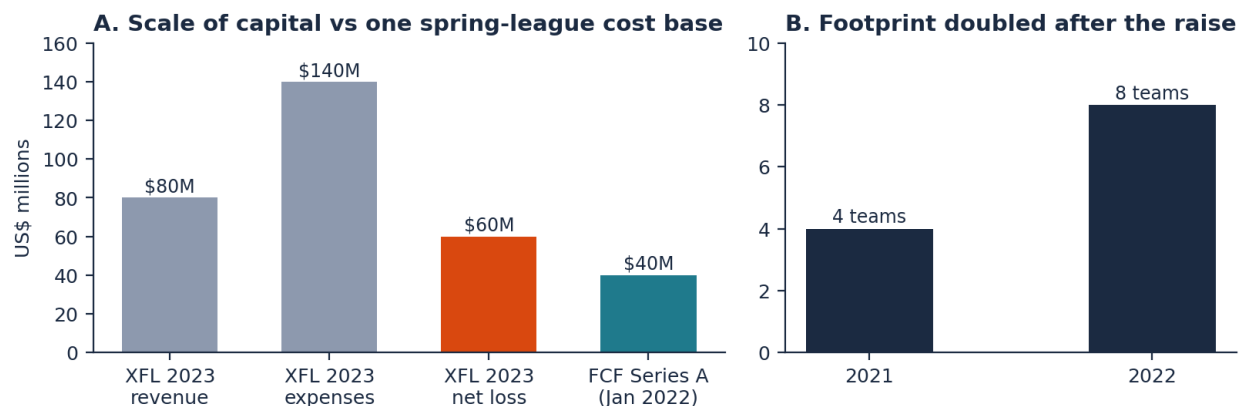
40 returned (teal) 60 did not (orange)
League-provided figure; underlying roster counts not published

Figure 4. Roster retention, 2021 to 2022 (league-provided).

4.4 Capital: scale ahead of proof

The \$40 million Series A is capital raised, not revenue. After it closed, FCF moved from four to eight teams and from one arena to a different Atlanta venue. For scale, the XFL's reported 2023 season involved roughly \$80 million of revenue against \$140 million of expenses, a \$60 million loss; at that cost structure \$40 million would last about eight months. FCF's actual cost base is not public and was likely smaller, so this is an order-of-magnitude illustration only. It does show that a single raise, even a large one, covers a short operating runway for a league that has not yet found revenue. Contemporary reporting later linked much of FCF's funding to the crypto boom, whose reversal removed the investor channel the model relied on.

Figure 5. Capital raised versus the cost of operating at scale



XFL figures are reported gross revenue and expenses for one season at larger scale. The comparison illustrates order of magnitude only: \$40M is about 8 months of the XFL's reported 2023 loss.

Figure 5. Scale of capital versus one spring-league cost base (left) and the team-count expansion that followed funding (right).

The chart illustrates the timeline of the USFL's development and challenges. A vertical line marks the start of 2022. The timeline is divided into three main periods: 2021, 2022, and 2023. Key events are marked with colored dots (blue for positive/neutral, red for negative) and labeled with text.

Category	Event / Challenge	Approximate Date
Capital	Series A \$40M	Early 2022
Capital	Funding weakens	Mid 2022
Capital	Cash crunch, season 3 cancelled	Early 2023
Product / scale	Season 1 4 teams	Early 2021
Product / scale	Season 2 8 teams	Mid 2022
Product / scale	Season 3 postponed	Early 2023
Competition	USFL launch same day (Apr 16)	Mid 2022
Labor	Only 40% of 2021 players return	Mid 2022

A note at the bottom indicates that the cancellation of Season 3 occurred about 17 months after the initial raise in early 2022.

5. Mechanism: the engagement-to-capital gap

Figure 7. Proposed failure mechanism: engagement-to-capital gap plus roster churn

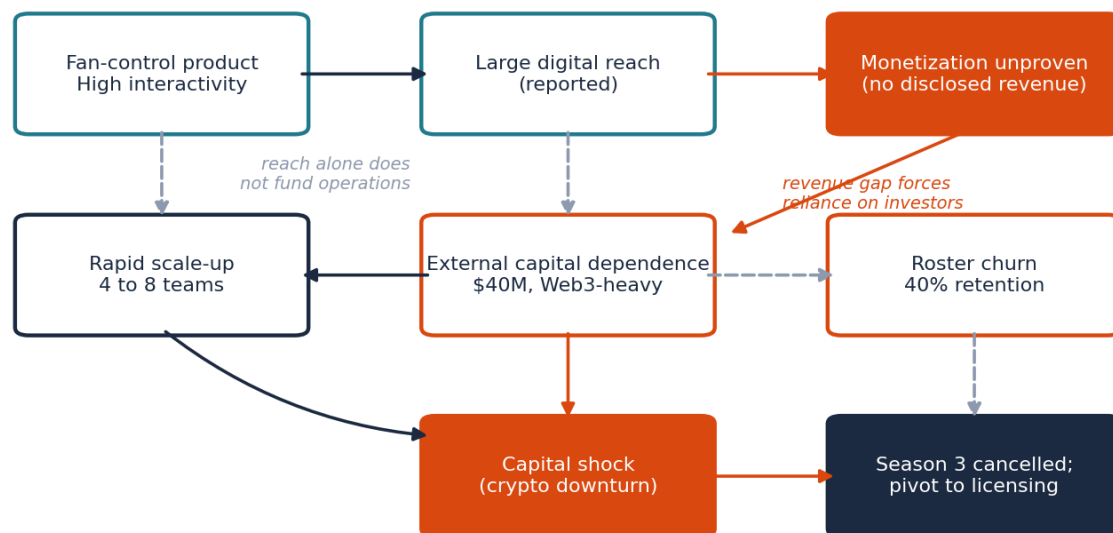


Figure 7. Working causal model. Solid orange arrows have direct public support; dashed grey arrows are inferred.

6. Competing explanations

Figure 8 scores seven hypotheses on three criteria, each coded 0-2: whether the underlying fact is documented, how directly it could cause a shutdown, and whether the evidence is specific to FCF rather than generic to the category. Scores are analyst judgments and are provided for transparency, not as measurements. Capital dependence scores highest (6/6). Player retention is well documented but causally indirect (5/6). The earlier brief rated it 'very strong', and this revision lowers it for that reason. Audience monetization is conceptually central but rests on the absence of disclosure, which is weaker than disclosed evidence (4/6). Competitive timing is documented (the 2022 season opened on the same date as the USFL), but FCF's reported reach grew that year, so it scores low as a cause (3/6).

Figure 8. Evidence scoring for each failure hypothesis (analyst-coded, 0-2 per criterion)

		Documented in public record	Causal proximity to shutdown	FCF-specific (not generic)
Capital dependence	[6/6]	2	2	2
Player retention	[5/6]	2	1	2
Crypto exposure	[4/6]	2	1	1
Audience monetization	[4/6]	1	2	1
Competitive timing	[3/6]	2	0	1
Venue economics	[3/6]	1	1	1
Product complexity	[2/6]	1	1	0

Figure 8. Rubric-based evidence scores. Criteria and scores are listed in the workbook so they can be re-coded.

Figure 9. Evidence-gap map: what the public record contains (NR = not reliably reported)

	Audience (own platform)	Audience (TV-measured)	Attendance	Revenue	Expenses	Net loss	Funding raised
FCF 2021-22	reported	NR	NR	NR	NR	NR	reported
XFL 2023	NR	reported	reported	reported	reported	reported	NR
USFL 2022	NR	reported	reported	reported	NR	NR	NR
UFL 2024	NR	reported	NR	NR	NR	NR	NR
NFL 2022	NR	NR	reported	reported	NR	NR	NR
FBS 2022	NR	NR	reported	reported	reported	NR	NR
CFL 2023	NR	NR	reported	NR	NR	NR	NR

Figure 9. Public-record coverage by league. FCF is the only row with no disclosed revenue, attendance or loss figure, which is the main constraint on this study.

7. Limitations

No audited FCF financials, attendance figures or per-game audience series are public, so revenue, margins and break-even cannot be estimated. Audience figures are league-reported and use inconsistent definitions across releases. Retention is a single league-provided percentage without a denominator. The sample is 12 team-seasons, which supports description and exploratory association only. The sequence of capital loss and cancellation is documented, but the relative contribution of weak monetization, crypto exposure and

expansion cost cannot be separated with current data. The rubric in Figure 8 is subjective.

8. Conclusion

FCF did not fail for lack of attention. It failed to show that attention could pay for the league before the capital that bridged the gap disappeared, and it did so while rebuilding most of its roster. The distinction matters for anyone designing a digital-first sports property: engagement metrics are not a business model, and a raise earlier than the revenue evidence can convert a runway into a deadline. Future work should seek the operator's financials, game-level viewership, and player interviews, which would allow the rubric to be replaced by estimates.

Appendix A. Selected statistics

Statistic	Value	Note
Win% vs point diff (Pearson)	$r = 0.52$, $p = 0.085$	$n = 12$, pooled
Win% vs point diff (Spearman)	$\rho = 0.59$, $p = 0.044$	$n = 12$, pooled
Scoring per team-game	33.8 (2021) vs 27.3 (2022)	-19%
2022 champion rank by point diff	8 of 8	Zappers, -38
Audience growth 2021 wk1 to playoffs	+186%	735K to 2.1M
Series A per 2022 team	\$5.0M	Illustrative, not allocation
Series A to cancellation	about 17 months	Jan 2022 to Jun 2023

Appendix B. Principal sources

FCF Series A announcement (PR Newswire, Jan 2022); Washington Post, 8 June 2022 (2.4M weekly views, 250K downloads, 40% retention); Sports Business Journal, June 2022; season records for the 2021 and 2022 FCF seasons and their teams (Wikipedia and archived league recaps); XFL 2023 season reporting for revenue, expenses and attendance; Sports Business Journal and NBC Sports for USFL and UFL audiences; NCAA research for FBS finances. Full URLs are in the workbook's Sources sheet.